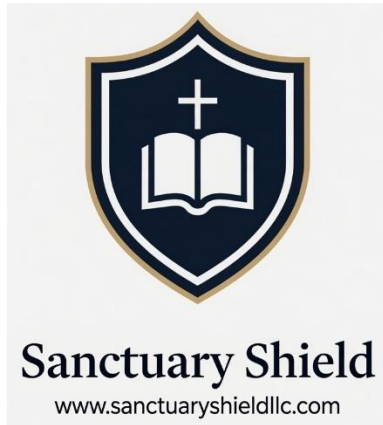




De-Escalation

De-escalation is the art and discipline of reducing the intensity of a tense or potentially volatile situation through calm, deliberate communication, positioning, and decision-making before it escalates into physical conflict or harm.

In a church context, it is not weakness or avoidance of responsibility; it is a faithful expression of wisdom, self-control, and love for neighbor (Proverbs 15:1; James 1:19–20). It aligns with the biblical call to be “wise as serpents

and innocent as doves” (Matthew 10:16), seeking first to protect life, preserve testimony, and uphold the peace of the gathered Body of Christ while remaining prepared to act decisively if de-escalation fails.

Effective de-escalation rests on the foundation that most church disruptions, disturbances, or confrontations begin with emotion, confusion, mental health challenges, personal crisis, or misunderstanding rather than premeditated malice. The goal is to create space for the individual to regain composure, redirect their energy, or exit the premises peacefully, while protecting the congregation and the ministry of the Word. Security team members must approach every interaction with humility, recognizing that the person in front of them -even if acting in a way that threatens others – is not beyond God’s grace.

1. Maintain Personal Composure

Your demeanor is your most powerful tool. Adrenaline, fear, or anger in the responder can rapidly escalate a situation. Breathe deeply, speak in a calm, low, steady tone, and adopt an open, non-threatening posture (hands visible, palms up or at sides, relaxed shoulders). Project confidence without aggression. Team members should practice this through role-playing drills so it becomes second nature.

2. Listen Actively and Validate Emotion

People in crisis often feel unheard. Allow them to speak without immediate interruption. Use phrases like, “I can see you’re upset,” or “Help me understand what’s going on.” Validation does not mean agreement with their actions or beliefs—it acknowledges their feelings as real to them. This often lowers defenses and opens a path toward compliance.

3. Use Collaborative Language

Avoid accusatory “you” statements (“You are causing a problem”). Instead, employ “I” language: “I want to make sure everyone stays safe,” or “I’m here to help resolve this.” Frame requests as shared goals: “Let’s step outside so we can talk without disrupting the service.”

4. Control Positioning

Respect personal space—standing too close can feel threatening. Position yourself at an angle (not directly facing) to reduce confrontation while maintaining situational awareness. Use team positioning to create a subtle containment corridor that gently guides the individual toward an exit, keeping the path of least resistance open. Never corner someone unless necessary for safety.

5. Offer Choices and Time

Distressed individuals often feel powerless. Restore some sense of control by offering limited, acceptable choices: “Would you prefer to talk here quietly or step into the lobby?” or “We can continue this conversation outside, or I can have someone walk with you to your car.” Give them time to process—rushing increases resistance.

6. Redirect and Distract

Shift focus from the grievance to practical next steps. For someone ranting about doctrine or a personal slight, gently redirect: “I hear your concern about that teaching. Let’s have one of our pastors follow up with you after the service so you can share your thoughts fully.”

Techniques and Tactics

Security volunteers should cycle rapidly through Observe (what is the person’s body language, tone? What is in immediate danger? What can be used to isolate? Deflect?), Orient (What is the context? Is there a history with the individual? What potentially triggered this aggression? Is there obvious impairment?), Decide (best course: engage verbally, isolate, or transition to removal), and Act (Take the next best action based on the decision. Leverage all resources and be ready to change if the action is ineffective or thwarted). Techniques such as “strip phrases” (“I understand...”) or empathy statements reduce hostility. Avoid debating theology or policy in the moment—postpone to a controlled setting. Ensure only one communicator speaks while others provide silent support (positioning, monitoring exits, preparing for backup). Use subtle hand signals or radios. A unified, calm team presence is far more effective than multiple voices. Whenever possible, move the interaction away from the main congregation—into a hallway, foyer, or outside. Close interior doors and open exterior doors to prevent placing the violent person in a corner (provide a way of escape). Do not pursue if the person leaves the immediate premises. This protects worship and reduces the audience that can fuel performance or escalation. Every de-escalation should be followed by a factual incident report. This protects the church legally and allows patterns (e.g., repeat offenders) to be addressed through pastoral care, trespass warnings, or law enforcement involvement as needed.

When De-escalation Is Not an Option

De-escalation has limits. If there are signs of imminent deadly threat (visible weapon, explicit threats of violence, or aggressive physical action), the response shifts immediately to protection of life using the church’s Physical Threat or Active Shooter

procedures. Training must emphasize the difference between a loud, angry person and someone actively trying to harm others. Legal standards in most jurisdictions support reasonable force, including deadly force, when there is an objectively reasonable belief of imminent death or serious bodily injury to oneself or others.

Sanctuary Shield, LLC

www.sanctuaryshieldllc.com

7/13/26